

Sound Decisions

PC speakers have come a long way from being just one part of a 'multimedia kit'. They have graduated to full-blown kits of their own with support for Dolby Digital 5.1. Also, with a lot of integrated soundcard solutions now available, people have started spending more money on speakers. There is now a perceptible difference in the quality and the choices available, with more than 10 different manufacturers competing in each price segment. Also, a lot of users now prefer buying 2.1 or higher speaker setups because of the better sound quality.

SMART TIPS

Power output: Most manufacturers list the PMPO output, but this is unreliable. Try and find out the RMS rating of the speakers instead. For general use, even about 4W RMS per channel would be sufficient.

Multi-speaker sets: These use a separate unit to reproduce the lower frequency band (20 to 300 Hz). This means that you will have two satellites and a subwoofer. There are other 4.1 and higher speaker sets which will require a special soundcard.

Bass reflex: This is a speaker with a hole or slot in the cabinet that allows sound inside the cabinet to emerge into the listening room. Bass reflex speakers have deeper bass extension than speakers with sealed cabinets.

Treble: Treble sounds range from frequencies of 2,500 Hz to 20,000 Hz. Too much of upper treble, say about 10,000 Hz, would give that "ssssss" sound instead of the



"sssshhh" sound over the main cymbal sound. Treble should sound like an integral part of the music, not a detached noise riding on top of it.

Midrange: The Midrange starts roughly from 300 Hz and may stretch up to 2000 Hz. Most of the musical energy is in the midrange, particularly the important lower harmonics of most instruments. This region contains most of the musical energy. The sound of human voice, rustling of leaves and the sounds of other animals is also concentrated in this band.

Bass: Deep bass would probably be at 16 Hz—the lower the frequency, deeper the bass performance. The popular belief is that more the bass, the better the sound. Correct bass reproduction is essential for a satisfying musical reproduction. Although reproducing the sudden attack of bass is vital, equally important is the system's ability to reproduce a fast decay, i.e. how a note ends.

Also Remember...

- The build quality should be sturdy enough to sustain vibrations and should not resonate.
- Tone, treble, base and volume controls should be easily accessible, preferably on the front fascia of the system.
- The placement of the speakers is key for quality sound reproduction.
 - a) Toe-in or angle-in the speakers so that they form a triangle with the listener.
 - b) The speakers should be placed at the same height as the listener's ears.
 - c) The subwoofer should be placed in a corner of the room.

	General desktop use	Home entertainment	Gaming and graphics professionals
You need	A speaker for listening to music occasionally. Audio quality is not a big issue as long as it "sounds ok"	A decently powered speaker set. You listen to music all the time and enjoy gaming to a certain extent	Movies, music, gaming. Complete home entertainment is what you want with loads of power
Look for	Any amplified two-speaker set with bass/treble/tone controls on the fascia of the set	A speaker set with a subwoofer and a combined RMS rating of at least 15 watts and higher. Also look out for a good 4.1 set if it fits in your budget	Minimum 4.1/5.1, Dolby Digital decoder with a combined RMS of over 30 watts
Our pick	Mercury SW480 Microtek Xplore Josh VX 820	Creative PC Works 2.1 Jetway Artis Creative FPS 1000	Logitech Xtrusio DSR 100 Creative Cambridge DTT2500
Price range	Up to Rs 1,000	From Rs 1,000 to Rs 8,000	Rs 8,000 and above

